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Myanmar: An Introduction

GEOGRAPHY

Myanmar is the largest country in mainland Southeast Asia, with approximately 262,000 square miles of territory. Most of the country lies in the latitudes of the tropics, with an abundance of natural resources, fertile land, and plentiful rainfall. Poor agricultural practices along with recurrent natural disasters have created problems for the people of Myanmar. Furthermore, malarial conditions make significant areas of the country uninhabitable. The length of the country stretches over 1,270 miles and it is 580 miles wide at its broadest point. The country borders China on the north and northeast; Laos and Thailand to the east; India and Bangladesh to the northwest; and the Bay of Bengal and the Andaman Sea to the south and west.

Geography impedes national development in Myanmar. The southern part of the country resembles Malaysia, while the north is much more like India or China, and the center falls somewhere in between. With such geographic diversity in land structure, nation building has always been problematic. The first geographic characteristic is the lowland area around the Irrawaddy and Chindwin Rivers. This area is the heartland of Myanmar in which most ethnic Burman and lowlands' groups have lived and worked predominately as rice farmers for most of the past millennium. The second distinctive region consists of rugged mountains and plateaus inhabited by numerous hill tribes. Populations such as the Kachin and Chin would be examples of tribal groups in the mountain areas. The mountains also provide a barrier from potential invasion. The physical separation of the different people has created a sense of disconnect that has historically impeded national unification efforts.